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**Challenges Faced by Non-Native English-Speaking Adults in Online Speaking Courses:
A Critical Review of Empirical Studies**

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Declaration

I hereby declare that the substance of this dissertation is entirely the result of my own investigation and that due reference or acknowledgement is made, whenever necessary, to the work of other researchers.

I am duly informed that any person practicing plagiarism will be subject to disciplinary sanctions issued by university authorities under the rules and regulations in force.

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Dedications

Heddouche Mohamed Housseem Eddine

I dedicate this to my loving parents who worked so hard to raise and educate me, to my siblings who are always there for me, and to my friends for their constant support and help. I am grateful and appreciative of each and every single one of them for being in my life, and helping me reach this stage.

Ahasniou Nesrine

In the name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful. All praise is due to Allah, who guided my steps and surrounded me with strength and grace along the way. This work is dedicated to my precious parents, Abdelouadoud and Zoulikha, whose presence, sacrifices, and quiet strength have shaped who I am today. To my siblings, marwa, mounib and abderrahmane, whose company has been part of the foundation that carried me through. To my dear Mamas and Khaled, whose warmth and generous heart turned their home into a space where I could grow, and continue this long journey. To my beloved uncles, aunts, and all those in the greater family who have been part of this journey. To my friends and companions, whose support and friendship have been a constant light throughout this chapter. And to my Cosmo Gym family, where I found not only strength, but a renewed sense of self, confidence, and encouragement that carried me forward.

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Show (thy) gratitude to Allah. Any who is (so) grateful does so to the profit of his own soul: but if any is ungrateful, verily Allah is free of all wants, Worthy of all praise.” Surat Luqman (31:12). **All praise and glory go to Allah.**

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Abstract

This secondary research addresses the challenges faced by adult non-native English speakers in online speaking courses, a growing and understudied area in language education. The research employs a theoretical and empirical review, analyzing affective, cognitive, and technology-based theories alongside three key studies from Chile, China, and Indonesia. These studies provide insights into the factors influencing speaking performance in online environments. Major findings reveal that while asynchronous formats reduce anxiety by allowing self-paced practice, they can limit spontaneous communication. Synchronous tasks, though interactive, often raise stress due to real time evaluation and technical difficulties. And self-efficacy emerged as a critical predictor of speaking success, outweighing anxiety alone.

Keywords: Online speaking courses, Adult EFL learners, Foreign language anxiety (FLA), Speaking challenges

List of Acronyms

EFL: English as a Foreign Language

ESL: English as a Second Language

FLA: Foreign Language Anxiety

FLCAS: Foreign Language Classroom Anxiety Scale

ZPD: Zone of Proximal Development

SAMR: Substitution, Augmentation, Modification, Redefinition

TPACK: Technological Pedagogical Content Knowledge

CoI: Community of Inquiry

TEM-4: Test for English Majors

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General Introduction

Online language learning has been developed a lot over recent years, it has particularly changed how people learn languages all over the world; this has been possible with the development of digital technology, easy access to the internet, and the rising need for flexible learning options. Recently, a wide variety of courses and resources are available on online platforms, allowing students to study whenever and wherever they prefer with less constraints than the traditional onsite lessons. Mostly, for adult learners who have particular difficulties when following learning a language since they have to manage their studies with full-time jobs, responsibilities, and other personal commitments, online learning's flexibility is a useful solution.

Speaking is considered as the most challenging of the four language skills, listening, reading, writing, and speaking, especially for adult learners learning online; it includes the capacity to manage pronunciation, interact with people in real time, and make language on the spot in addition to having a good understanding of grammar and vocabulary. Yet, adult learners of English as a second or foreign language frequently face a number of challenges when taking online speaking courses by limiting immediate feedback, reducing gestures, and sometimes building feelings of anxiety or isolation, a lack of opportunities for real world conversation practice, and technical difficulties with using digital tools and platforms, so online learning environments can limit these opportunities.

Even if online language learning has been deeply studied in the past, but little attention has been paid to how adult non-native English speakers interact with online speaking courses, and because the mentioned difficulties can affect students' motivation and development, educators have to better understand and meet the needs of these learners. Thus, due to this gap in the research, important facts regarding the backgrounds, objectives, and learning preferences of adult learners may go unnoticed.

This dissertation main goal is to explore and analyze the main difficulties that adult non-native speakers face when taking online English-speaking courses, as mentioned

by previous empirical research. This study aims to identify recurrent issues, investigate how these issues are framed and discussed in the research field. The fact that adult learners make up different and expanding portion of the language learning population makes this study especially important. Adults needs are different from those of younger students who might have different psychological and social learning profiles. Furthermore, it is crucial to understand adults online learning experiences and this constant development of online education, which has been especially sped up by world events like the COVID-19 pandemic.

The dissertation is structured as follows: Key terms, definitions, theoretical frameworks and a presentation of opposing points of view related to online education and adult language learning are introduced in the first chapter. A comprehensive critical analysis of three empirical studies from different countries and a discussion of the different findings that look at adult non-native English speakers' experiences in online speaking courses is provided in the second chapter. Lastly, the conclusion summarizes the key findings of this research and gives a synthesis of the research problem.

This work attempts to provide an analysis of the challenges that may disrupt adult learners' progress in online English-speaking environments and to shed light on how to improve this area of language learning.

Part One: Theoretical Background

1.1. Introduction

This chapter gives a clear overview of the main theories that explain how adults learn to speak English in online classes. It looks at three important areas: how feelings and emotions affect learning, how motivation and beliefs play a role, and how technology changes the way we learn. First, the chapter explains some key words and ideas, such as; the meaning of EFL adult learners, speaking skills, and online language learning. It also discusses important theories, such as Krashen's Affective Filter Hypothesis, Bandura's Self-Efficacy Theory, and the Community of Inquiry model; these theories help us to see why some learners feel anxious, how confidence can help or hurt progress, and why technology can be both helpful and challenging.

1.2. Definitions of Key Concepts

For better understanding and clarity, this section defines the key concepts and terms that are related to the topic, and also used in this study.

1.2.1. English as a Foreign Language (EFL)

EFL refers to the study or use of English by non-native speakers in regions where English is not the primary language spoken; EFL learners engage with the language mostly in educational or institutional settings where exposure to authentic communication can be limited compared to ESL contexts; however, in EFL classes, learners often struggle to find opportunities for genuine interaction which is crucial for to develop their fluency.

1.2.2. Adult Learners

Adult learners are individuals who engage in formal education beyond the typical school age; they bring with them a range of life experiences, motivations, and responsibilities that influence how they approach learning; unlike younger learners, adults are typically more self-directed and goal-oriented; however, they may also

carry anxieties about returning to education, struggle with confidence, and require learning environments that are relevant, respectful, and flexible.

1.2.3. Speaking Skills in Language Learning

Speaking is a productive language skill which involves real-time communication and interaction; it also includes subskills such as fluency, pronunciation, grammatical accuracy, vocabulary control, and pragmatic competence. In language education, speaking is often considered as the most difficult to teach and learn due to its spontaneous, performative nature and the pressure of being understood clearly, for EFL learners, the lack of real world practice and immediate feedback can further complicate skill development, particularly in online environments.

1.2.4. Online Language Learning

Online language learning involves the use of internet-based tools, platforms, and technologies to deliver language instruction. It can be synchronous (e.g., video conferencing) or asynchronous (e.g., discussion forums, recorded lectures), It gives learners advantages such as flexibility and learning at their own pace. However, it also introduces new barriers, such as technological discomfort, reduced immediacy, and feelings of isolation, all of which can affect learner engagement and oral participation.

Understanding these terms is essential before exploring how different theories help explain the learning difficulties that arise in online EFL speaking instruction, particularly for adult learners.

1.3. Affective and Emotional Theories

One of the most prominent factors influencing language learning success is emotion. Feelings of anxiety, fear of failure, or low self confidence can significantly affect a learner's ability to perform in speaking task, especially when these tasks are conducted online, where technical issues and a lack of immediate human presence may worsen emotional discomfort.

1.3.1. Krashen's Affective Filter Hypothesis (1982)

Stephen Krashen's hypothesis assumes that learners acquire language more effectively when they are motivated, relaxed, and confident. A high "affective filter," triggered by anxiety or low self-esteem, can block language input from being processed by the brain, even when exposure is sufficient. In online settings, learners may feel more vulnerable due to factors like camera use, unfamiliar platforms, or delayed responses, all of which can increase anxiety and raise the affective filter, for adult learners who may already doubt their abilities or feel out of place in a digital classroom, this barrier can be particularly pronounced.

1.3.2. Horwitz's Foreign Language Classroom Anxiety Scale (FLCAS, 1986)

Elaine Horwitz and colleagues introduced the FLCAS to measure language-specific anxieties in educational settings; This scale identifies communication apprehension, test anxiety, and fear of negative evaluation as major sources of language anxiety; also these anxieties often escalate in speaking tasks, particularly online,

where learners worry about how their pronunciation or accent is perceived by peers and instructors, also the lack of body language in online environments may heighten the fear of making mistakes or being judged.

These theories emphasize that emotional factors are not a side issue, they are rather central to language development. For speaking in particular, lowering emotional barriers is essential for active participation.

1.4. Cognitive and Motivational Theories

In addition to emotions, learners' thoughts and beliefs about their own abilities greatly influence their performance; for instance, adult learners often carry specific expectations,

goals, and doubts that shape their engagement with online courses.

1.4.1. Bandura's Self-Efficacy Theory (1997)

Albert Bandura defines self-efficacy as a person's belief in his/her ability to perform a particular task successfully, and according to Bandura (1997) this personal belief has an influence on individual motivation, effort, persistence, and resilience to face different challenges. In addition, in language learning, high self-efficacy is linked to greater participation, more risk-taking in communication, and sustained effort. In contrast, learners with low self-efficacy may avoid speaking tasks, particularly online where social cues are harder to interpret. Adult learners may have had negative school experiences or long gaps in formal education, leading to doubts about their ability to improve or succeed, particularly when it involves using digital tools.

1.4.2. Andragogy (Knowles, 1980s)

Malcolm Knowles' theory of adult learning (andragogy) outlines five key assumptions: adults are self-directed, bring life experiences to learning, are goal-oriented, seek relevance, and are internally motivated. Online speaking courses that fail to accommodate these principles, for example by being too rigid, abstract, or impersonal, may lose adult learners' interest. On the other hand, when courses are aligned with learners' real life communication needs and give them control over their progress, motivation and participation increase.

These frameworks help educators design more effective online speaking environments that take into account not just what learners need to know, but how they perceive themselves as learners.

1.5. Technology-Based and Online Learning Theories

The online nature of modern EFL speaking courses brings its own unique opportunities and limitations. Several frameworks have been developed to explain how technology influences learning outcomes.

1.5.1. Community of Inquiry (Garrison et al., 2000)

The Community of Inquiry model suggests that get a successful online learning instruction requires three types of presence: cognitive (engagement with the material), teaching (instruction and feedback), and social (a sense of connection with others), for speaking courses, social presence is crucial; without a feeling of interpersonal connection, learners may remain silent or disengaged, so courses that neglect this aspect, focusing too much on lectures and limiting group interaction, may fail to stimulate oral participation.

1.5.2. Vygotsky's Sociocultural Theory: Constructivism

According to Vygotsky language acquisition occurs through interaction within the Zone of Proximal Development (ZPD) where learners can achieve more with guidance or collaboration than alone, so he emphasized that learning is rather socially mediated. In practice, Online learning platforms can foster collaborative learning only when they are designed to support dialogue, peer feedback, and cooperative tasks, however, many platforms focus on passive consumption of content, and they miss opportunities for authentic speaking practice.

1.5.3. SAMR and TPACK Model

Technological integration models like SAMR (Substitution, Augmentation, Modification, Redefinition) and TPACK (Technological Pedagogical Content Knowledge) provide the teachers with useful frameworks to evaluate how effectively technology enhances learning. Online speaking courses that merely substitute face to face interaction with basic video calls may not yield meaningful learning; however, online courses that encourage interactions through speech recognition tools, roleplay simulations, or interactive peer assessment platforms may significantly improve learners' outcomes.

1.5.4. Salmon's E-Moderating Model (2000)

Gilly Salmon's E-Moderating Model outlines a five stages framework that facilitate the online learning experiences; these stages are Access and Motivation,

Online Socialization, Information Exchange, Knowledge Construction and Development; they all highlight the progressive nature of learners' engagement in online environments; this model is particularly relevant for online speaking instruction as it emphasizes the importance of building community and gradually increasing the cognitive complexity of tasks. Adult learners benefit from this scaffolded approach, which helps to reduce initial technological anxiety and supports sustained participation. When facilitators are trained to moderate discussions effectively, learners are more likely to collaborate, speak up, and build confidence in their language use. The above models collectively argue that technology alone doesn't guarantee learning, but the pedagogical design and quality of interaction that determine success.

1.6. Opposing and Critical Perspectives

While the above mentioned theories provide valuable insight into EFL speaking instruction, they are not without criticism; for example, Krashen's Affective Filter Hypothesis, has been criticized for its lack of empirical testability and vague operational definitions. In addition, Horwitz's FLCAS, even it is widely used, may oversimplify the complex and culturally shaped nature of language anxiety. Bandura's self-efficacy theory, though influential, can overlook systemic and contextual barrier, like limited internet access or poor instructional design that affect learners' actual performance.

Moreover, some scholars argue that technology integration theories like SAMR are overly idealistic and ignore the digital divide; for example, adult learners from disadvantaged backgrounds may not have the digital fluency or equipment to fully benefit from online learning, regardless of how well a course is designed; therefore, while these theories are useful, they should be applied with awareness of real-world limitations.

1.7. Conclusion

This chapter presented a theoretical foundation for examining the challenges faced by adult non-native English speakers in online speaking courses, so through the definitions of key concepts and a structured review of affective, cognitive, and technology-based theories, it established the multifaceted nature of language learning in digital spaces; these frameworks offer valuable insight into how emotions, beliefs, and instructional design shape learners' experiences. The next chapter will apply this theoretical lens to a critical review of empirical studies, aiming to identify the most common and impactful challenges reported in the literature.

Part Two: Review of Empirical Studies

2.1. Introduction

To understand the existing speaking challenges faced by non-native adults in online speaking courses, this part will review three empirical studies from three different geographical areas. The studies chosen for the review all have the same pedagogical context of adult learners in higher education, with each study mainly using the Foreign Language Classroom Anxiety Scale (FLCAS) (Horwitz et al., 1986), ensuring methodological consistency for the comparison. The review examines: Anxiety sources (fear of evaluation, low self-confidence...etc), impact on speaking performance, pedagogical and environmental influences, and relations to concepts and theories developed in the theoretical background. Based on the analysis of these findings; this section addresses the research problem by identifying key factors and challenges faced by non-native English-speaking adults in online speaking courses.

2.1 Overview of the Three Studies

2.1.1. Véliz-Campos et al. (2023) article

The study by Véliz-Campos et al. (2023) investigated the difficulties leading to FLA, as well as the correlation between FLA and oral performance. The study was done on 38 Chilean law students, equally gendered (19 male, 19 female), in blended (online + in person) EFL courses post-COVID-19. The researchers employed a mixed-method approach, and used an adapted Spanish version of the FLCAS (Horwitz et al., 1986), oral performances for Human Rights presentations, and semi-structured interviews to triangulate data. A negative correlation was found between test anxiety and oral performance, and students reported less interaction quality in online setting. Additionally, qualitative data showed that peer judgment and fear of immediate feedback were primary stress factors.

2.1.2. Gao et al. (2023) article

Gao et al.'s (2023) researched foreign language anxiety and its influencing factors among Chinese undergraduates in fully online EFL courses during COVID-19. The large-scale study was done on 102 participants equally gendered. Employing a multi-method approach, researchers used FLCAS, analyzed TEM-4 proficiency scores (TEM-4 examines listening, reading, and writing), and conducted follow-up interviews. Their analysis revealed two dominant anxiety dimensions: fear of inadequate performance strongly tied to academic perfectionism, and lack of confidence increased by insufficient teacher feedback. Qualitative data further highlighted how technological barriers—such as audio lag and platform instability—intensified anxiety during synchronous (occurring at the same time) assessments. The findings of the study highlight the effect of technological and pedagogical structures on students' performance in fully online language learning environments.

2.1.3. Hakim (2022) article

Hakim's (2022) research investigated the relationship between anxiety and performance in online English-speaking classes. Using a quantitative approach, 98 Sundanese Language and Culture Study Program students (32 male and 66 female) were examined in asynchronous (not occurring at the same time) online EFL courses. The study used an FLCAS questionnaire alongside speaking scores. Key findings revealed moderate overall anxiety levels, with fear of negative evaluation emerging as the primary stressor, which reflected the cultural significance of "malu" (shame) in this context. The study also found a weak negative correlation between anxiety and speaking performance, which researchers attributed to the asynchronous format, specifically the ability to record multiple attempts before submission.

2.2. Similarities

Three fundamental similarities can be found from the comparative analysis of the studies. First, all three studies identified evaluation scenarios such as oral presentations (Chile), formal English proficiency tests (China), and recorded speaking videos (Indonesia) as central sources of anxiety. These findings confirm that test related stress is a reoccurring factor, which shows the importance of task design

and learner support in managing performance based anxiety. Second, learner confidence played a critical role in shaping anxiety outcomes. Students who engaged in proactive strategies like rehearsing (China), recording multiple video takes (Indonesia), or using asynchronous tools (Chile) showed better coping and performance. This highlights the value of self directed learning which helps learners feel in control of their progress and that risk taking is minimized. Third, the FLCAS proved to be a useful diagnostic tool across all contexts. While quantitative scores varied slightly, all three studies showed that FLA remains a reliable and relevant measure even in online environments, especially when adapted to reflect context specific stress factors.

2.3. Differences

Despite the shared elements, the studies also revealed important differences in how cultural values and delivery formats influence learners' anxiety experiences and performance.

Culturally, Chilean learners experienced anxiety closely linked to social visibility and peer perception during live presentations, suggesting a performance-focused mindset that prioritizes external judgment. In China, anxiety was more related to academic outcomes and pressure to achieve especially under exam conditions, which led to measurable declines in proficiency scores for the students. In contrast, Indonesian learners who come from a collectivist academic culture, were more concerned with avoiding public embarrassment or making mistakes, even in a relatively private, asynchronous setting. They preferred preparing polished video submissions rather than participating directly.

The impact of the instructional format also varied significantly. In Chile and China, synchronous activities intensified anxiety due to real time pressure, limited technical reliability, and reduced opportunities for preparation. While in Indonesia, the asynchronous format provided students with better flexibility and the option to re-record, which reduced anxiety and allowed for more polished results. However, this same flexibility may have resulted in surface level fluency as students avoided

spontaneous or unstructured speaking tasks. Interestingly, the strength of the correlation between anxiety and speaking performance differed across contexts. Chile and China's results showed a strong negative correlation, particularly for those with high anxiety around academic performance (in China). While Indonesia, showed only a weak negative correlation, which could be due to the recording format allowing learners to rehearse as much as needed, minimizing the visible impact of anxiety on performance. This finding raises questions about whether asynchronous tools mitigate anxiety or simply conceal it.

Another notable difference was the level of social interaction embedded in the learning design; for example, the study in Chile, included group discussions and peer evaluations, which created opportunities for collaborative learning and feedback, however,

China's online classes were more instructor centered, and the lack of peer interaction may have heightened feelings of isolation. Indonesia's format involved mainly independent work, with less opportunities for dialogue. This absence of interaction may have limited students' ability to build speaking confidence through low risk practice.

While each context successfully adapted to the demands of online learning, the extent to which technology enhanced or hindered learning depended heavily on how it was implemented. In Chile, educators appeared to use online tools to facilitate both speaking practice and peer collaboration, in contrast, China's experience revealed gaps in instructional support and technical training, and Indonesia's approach prioritized accessibility and convenience over real-time communication.

2.4. Critical Discussion of the findings

Drawing on the theoretical frameworks of Krashen's Affective Filter Hypothesis (1982), Horwitz's Foreign Language Classroom Anxiety Scale (FLCAS, 1986), Bandura's Self-Efficacy Theory (1997), and Salmon's E-Moderating Model (2000), this section critically analyzes the empirical findings from Chile, China, and Indonesia.

This discussion explores the impact of these frameworks on learner performance, addresses counterarguments, and synthesizes key insights in order to answer the research problem; additional insights are also drawn from Knowles' Andragogy, Garrison et al.'s Community of Inquiry (CoI), Vygotsky's Sociocultural Theory, and the SAMR and TPACK models to enrich the interpretation of online instructional practices.

In addition, the Chilean study (Véliz-Campos et al., 2023) demonstrates how learners' anxiety is lowered in online settings mostly when they use asynchronous tools such as video recordings, so this study shows how asynchronous tools allowed students to speak without the fear of instant judgment lower their affective filter and accordingly may enhance their performance.

These findings align with instructional principles of learner autonomy and self-pacing, suggesting that adult learners benefit from the flexibility afforded by asynchronous environments; for example, Vygotsky's sociocultural view is also reflected in students' use of peer feedback and collaborative tools, indicating that social interaction even when asynchronous, supports language development through mediated learning, in contrast, findings from China (Gao et al., 2023) show that online environments introduced different stressors (such as unstable internet and limited social interaction) which raised learners' anxiety and hindered speaking. These findings emphasize that while online learning may reduce traditional stressors like in-person peer pressure; it introduces its own challenges that can raise the affective filter in new ways, in this context, the CoI framework becomes relevant: cognitive presence may be sustained through structured content, but social presence often suffers without intentional facilitation, thus, weakening the overall learning experience.

In Chile, the FLCAS was adapted to assess anxiety levels across synchronous and asynchronous modalities. Results indicated that asynchronous tasks lessened communication nervousness and fear of negative evaluation (Véliz-Campos et al., 2023), likely due to the reduced urgency of peer and instructor feedback. Meanwhile, the Indonesian study (Hakim, 2022) found generally low anxiety levels; however, this

did not directly correlate with improved speaking performance. Although learners reported low anxiety, their cautious engagement (such as reliance on rehearsed videos) suggested hidden insecurities not fully captured by the scale. This suggests a limitation in applying FLCAS to online settings without accounting for digitally specific anxieties such as “camera shyness” or screen fatigue. Here, the TPACK model is applicable, teachers' limited ability to integrate pedagogical and technological knowledge may have contributed to reduced spontaneity and interaction, particularly in the Indonesian context.

Gao et al. (2023) found that Chinese students with high self-efficacy were more likely to participate in synchronous discussions and overcome technical difficulties. These learners demonstrated greater resilience and adaptability, even when confronted with unstable digital environments. In contrast, low self-efficacy learners exhibited avoidance behaviors, such as muting themselves or turning off cameras, thereby missing valuable speaking opportunities. Similarly, the Indonesian study found that learners' self-efficacy increased in asynchronous formats, where they could record and edit their responses (Hakim, 2022). The Chilean study also emphasized that reduced anxiety did not necessarily lead to improved performance; only students who believed in their ability to speak fluently showed real progress (Véliz-Campos et al., 2023). These findings align with Bandura's theory, confirming that confidence in one's speaking ability is as crucial as anxiety reduction. Moreover, CoI's notion of teaching presence is central here, since structured facilitation and feedback from instructors were shown to mediate self-efficacy, particularly in synchronous tasks.

The Chinese study (Gao et al., 2023) reflected many of Salmon's early stages. Students faced difficulties at Stage 1 (access and motivation) due to poor connectivity and lack of training in using digital platforms. This hindered their transition to Stage 2 (online socialization), resulting in feelings of isolation and decreased participation in speaking tasks. In contrast, when instructors implemented real-time interactive sessions, learners reported stronger motivation and peer connection, suggesting that effective e-moderation can mitigate these barriers. These stages also overlap with the

SAMR model's lower tiers, where technology substitutes traditional teaching but may not augment or redefine learning without additional pedagogical support.

In Indonesia, learners mostly engaged in asynchronous tasks. While they successfully navigated Stage 3 (information exchange) and Stage 4 (knowledge construction) by producing well-organized video responses, there was limited evidence of Stage 2 (social interaction) or Stage 5 (development), which involves reflecting and applying skills in new contexts (Hakim, 2022). Besides, the Chilean study has highlighted how e-moderation in blended models has encouraged both speaking confidence and peer collaboration (Véliz-Campos et al., 2023), so these findings affirm that Salmon's model is applicable, but requires careful adaptation for different cultural and technological contexts. In line with Vygotsky's theory, the lack of social scaffolding in asynchronous-only models may hinder students' ability to internalize speaking strategies through interaction within their Zone of Proximal Development (ZPD), and when online platforms appear to reduce certain anxiety triggers; they are not a solution for all learners. The Chilean data suggest that asynchronous learning reduces anxiety, but the lack of real-time communication may lead to over-reliance on preparation, which can hinder spontaneous language use, similarly, the Indonesian context shows low anxiety but minimal interaction, wondering whether students are genuinely developing communicative competence or simply avoiding difficult tasks. Moreover, the FLCAS may not fully capture technology-induced stress such as delays, device malfunction, or poor audio quality which are factors that are now integral to the online learning experience. These stressors are distinct from traditional classroom anxiety and suggest a need to revise or expand the FLCAS for digital contexts. Here, the SAMR model's higher levels (modification and redefinition) become relevant, as instructional designs that fully transform speaking tasks (such as real-time simulations or collaborative digital storytelling) may reduce these new stressors more effectively

Cultural norms also influence learners' responses to online education. For instance, in collectivist societies like China and Indonesia, learners may hesitate to speak up due to fear of disrupting group harmony or exposing their weaknesses

publicly. These sociocultural factors influence both self-efficacy and communication anxiety, thus requiring local interpretations of Bandura's and Krashen's frameworks. They also align with Vygotsky's view that learning is mediated by cultural tools and social norms. Additionally, the limited teaching presence and technological mediation reported in these studies suggest a partial application of the TPACK framework, where insufficient pedagogical-technical integration may have hindered learner interaction and confidence.

Drawing on empirical data and theoretical frameworks, we can conclude that online EFL learning environments can enhance speaking performance when they reduce affective barriers (Krashen, 1982) and promote learner confidence (Bandura, 1997). However, this is conditional upon the technological readiness and pedagogical support available to learners. Additionally, foreign language anxiety varies significantly across online modalities. Asynchronous tasks may reduce FLA (Horwitz, 1986), but without active participation and feedback, they risk hindering speaking practices. Moreover, self-efficacy plays a stronger role in determining speaking performance than anxiety alone. Learners who believe in their speaking ability are more likely to engage, even in stressful or unpredictable online environments. As well as, e-moderation (Salmon, 2000) being crucial for learner success, and teachers must guide students not only through technological access but also toward meaningful, socially enriched engagement.

In sum, the reviewed studies show that the transition to online speaking instruction is not merely a shift in medium, but a reconfiguration of learner psychology, instructional design, and technological intervention. The connection between affective factors, self-efficacy, and digital moderation must be carefully managed to ensure fair and effective language learning outcomes. Integrating Col's triad, TPACK alignment, and SAMR-based task design while remaining responsive to adult learners' needs (Andragogy), and sociocultural dynamics offers a better approach to improving online speaking instruction for non-native adult learners.

2.5. Conclusion

This review of three empirical studies highlights their goals in understanding speaking challenges in online EFL courses. It identifies their findings and where they share similarities, as well as where they differ. The comparison and contrast of those findings helps us better understand the most critical factors that must be paid attention to. Additionally, the discussion of the findings in relation to the theories and concepts helps make more sense of the findings. Across Chile, China, and Indonesia, test-related stress, fear of negative evaluation, and self-efficacy emerged as critical factors influencing speaking performance. These findings allow us to realize solutions for the stated research problem, as well as for online EFL courses in general.

General conclusion

This dissertation explored the challenges faced by adult non-native English speakers in online speaking courses, and tackle a significant gap in the literature regarding adults learners. This study aimed mainly to identify common obstacles reported in empirical research, analyze how these challenges are discussed in theoretical frameworks, and understand their impact on speaking performance. The first chapter established the theoretical foundation of this dissertation and defined key concepts, and reviewed affective and emotional theories like Krashen's Affective Filter Hypothesis and Horwitz's Foreign Language Classroom Anxiety Scale (FLCAS), cognitive and motivational theories such as Bandura's Self-Efficacy Theory and Knowles' Andragogy, and technology-based frameworks including the Community of Inquiry (CoI), Vygotsky's Sociocultural Theory, and Salmon's E-Moderating Model; these perspectives highlighted the multi sided nature of language learning in digital environments, emphasizing the interplay of emotions, beliefs, and instructional design.

The second chapter critically reviewed three empirical studies from Chile, China, and Indonesia, they all focused on adult learners in higher education and employing the FLCAS to assess language anxiety. The findings revealed recurring challenges such as fear of evaluation, low self-confidence, and technological barriers, while also underscoring the influence of cultural norms and instructional modalities. The key differences of this research emerged in how anxiety manifested across contexts, for example, with synchronous models which often intensify stress and asynchronous models which provide flexibility but potentially limiting spontaneous interaction. Moreover, the analysis confirmed that self-efficacy plays a pivotal role in speaking performance, and is often more significant than the impact of anxiety alone.

In summary, this dissertation demonstrated that online EFL speaking courses present unique challenges for adult learners, which are shaped by emotional,

cognitive, and technological factors. While asynchronous environments may reduce anxiety, but they risk to isolate learners and hindering communicative competence.

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Abstract in Arabic

يتناول هذا البحث الثانوي التحديات التي يواجهها متعلموا اللغة الإنجليزية البالغون غير الناطقين بها في دورات التحدث عبر الإنترنت. يستخدم البحث منهجية المراجعة النظرية والتجريبية، حيث يقوم بتحليل العوامل النظرية العاطفية والمعرفية والقائمة على التكنولوجيا، إلى جانب ثلاث دراسات رئيسية من تشيلي والصين وإندونيسيا. هذه الدراسات، تقدم مفهوم حول العوامل المؤثرة على أداء التحدث في البيئات الإلكترونية، حيث كشفت النتائج الرئيسية أنه بينما تقلل الدراسة الغير فورية من القلق من خلال السماح بالممارسة الذاتية، إلا أنها قد تحد من التواصل التلقائي. أما الدراسة الفورية، على الرغم من فاعليتها، فإنها غالبًا ما تزيد الضغط بسبب التقييم في الوقت الحقيقي والصعوبات التقنية. كما برزت الكفاءة الذاتية كعامل حاسم في نجاح التحدث، متفوقًا في أهميتها على القلق وحده. تؤكد الدراسة على الحاجة إلى تصميمات تعليمية متوازنة تدمج المرونة، والحضور الاجتماعي، واستراتيجيات بناء الثقة لدعم المتعلمين البالغين في دورات التحدث عبر الإنترنت.